Eigenvalues and diagonalization

Linear Algebra · Lecture of 11 November 2026

Last time (Chapters 1–6, before the midterm): linear systems, rank, determinants. Facts F1–F8 below are proved there; F9–F12 are facts about polynomials, used without proof here (see Chapter 7 of the textbook). Throughout, $I = I_n$ and e_j is column j of I.

Facts

F1. $(AB)C = A(BC)$, $A(B+C) = AB + AC$, $(A+B)C = AC + BC$, $c(AB) = (cA)B = A(cB)$ ($c \in \mathbb{R}$), $I_m A = A = AI_n$ ($A \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times n}$); $A + B$, cA entry by entry, with the vector rules.

F2. $A = [a_1 \ \cdots \ a_n]$: $Ax = x_1a_1 + \cdots + x_na_n$, $Ae_j = a_j$, $\operatorname{col}_j(AB) = A\operatorname{col}_j(B)$ (col_j: column j); matrices with the same columns are equal.

F3. $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ invertible $\Leftrightarrow$ ($Ax = 0 \Rightarrow x = 0$) $\Leftrightarrow \operatorname{rank} A = n \Leftrightarrow$ independent columns $\Leftrightarrow \det A \neq 0$.

F4. $cx = 0$, $x \neq 0 \Rightarrow c = 0$; a list containing 0 is dependent; $\dim W = d \Rightarrow$ any d independent vectors of W are a basis of W; $\dim \mathbb{R}^n = n$; an independent list in $\mathbb{R}^n$ extends to a basis.

F5. $A \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times n}$: $\mathcal{N}(A) = \{x : Ax = 0\}$ is a subspace, $\dim \mathcal{N}(A) = n - \operatorname{rank} A$, $\operatorname{rank}(PAQ) = \operatorname{rank} A$ (P, Q invertible); row operations keep $\mathcal{N}(A)$; $\operatorname{rank} A =$ number of nonzero rows of an echelon form; the special solutions of the reduced echelon form are a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A)$.

F6. $A, B \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$, $c \in \mathbb{R}$: $\det(AB) = \det A \det B$, $\det(cA) = c^n \det A$, $\det I = 1$, $\det A = a_{11}\cdots a_{nn}$ (A triangular); adding a multiple of a row (column) to another keeps $\det A$, scaling a row (column) by c scales $\det A$ by c.

F7. $n \geqslant 2$, $A(i|j) = A$ without row i and column j: $\det A = \sum_j (-1)^{i+j} a_{ij} \det A(i|j)$ (each i) $= \sum_i (-1)^{i+j} a_{ij} \det A(i|j)$ (each j).

F8. $M = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} P & Q \\ R & S \end{smallmatrix}\right)$, $P \in \mathbb{R}^{p\times p}$, $S \in \mathbb{R}^{q\times q}$: $R = 0 \Rightarrow \det M = \det P \det S$; P invertible $\Rightarrow \det M = \det P \det(S - RP^{-1}Q)$; S invertible $\Rightarrow \det M = \det S \det(P - QS^{-1}R)$.

Polynomials. $\mathbb{C} = \{a + b\mathrm{i} : a, b \in \mathbb{R}\}$, $\mathrm{i}^2 = -1$; $zw = 0 \Rightarrow z = 0$ or $w = 0$. A polynomial $f = b_0 + b_1 t + \cdots + b_m t^m$ has coefficients $b_k \in \mathbb{C}$ (constant term b_0; real if all $b_k \in \mathbb{R}$); $f + g$, fg have the coefficients $b_k + d_k$, $\sum_{i+j=k} b_i d_j$ ($g = \sum_k d_k t^k$). For $f \neq 0$, $\deg f$ is the largest k with $b_k \neq 0$; f is monic if $b_{\deg f} = 1$. Values: $f(z) = \sum_k b_k z^k$ ($z \in \mathbb{C}$), $f(A) = \sum_k b_k A^k$ (f real, $A^0 = I$, $A^{k+1} = A^k A$); $(f+g)(z) = f(z) + g(z)$, $(fg)(z) = f(z)g(z)$; z is a root if $f(z) = 0$.

F9. $f, g \neq 0 \Rightarrow fg \neq 0$, $\deg(fg) = \deg f + \deg g$. So $fg = fh$, $f \neq 0 \Rightarrow g = h$.

F10. (Factor theorem) For $c \in \mathbb{C}$: $f(c) = 0 \iff f = (t - c)q$ for some polynomial q.

F11. $f \neq 0$ of degree m has at most m roots. So $f(z) = g(z)$ for infinitely many $z \Rightarrow f = g$.

F12. A monic f of degree $n \geqslant 1$ is $f = (t - \lambda_1)\cdots(t - \lambda_n)$, $\lambda_i \in \mathbb{C}$, unique up to order (existence: fundamental theorem of algebra, not proved in this course); its roots are $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$; its coefficient of t^{n-1} is $-(\lambda_1 + \cdots + \lambda_n)$, its constant term $(-1)^n \lambda_1 \cdots \lambda_n$.

1. Eigenvalues and eigenvectors

Definition 1. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$. $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$ is an **eigenvalue** of A if $Ax = \lambda x$ for some $x \in \mathbb{R}^n$, $x \neq 0$; such x is an **eigenvector** belonging to λ. The **eigenspace** of λ is the subspace $\mathcal{N}(A - \lambda I) = \{x \in \mathbb{R}^n : Ax = \lambda x\}$ (F5); its nonzero vectors are the eigenvectors belonging to λ.

Theorem 2. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$, $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$. Then λ is an eigenvalue of $A \iff \det(\lambda I - A) = 0 \iff \operatorname{rank}(A - \lambda I) < n$.

Proof.

The chain of equivalences:

$$\begin{aligned} \lambda \text{ is an eigenvalue} &\iff (A-\lambda I)x = 0 \text{ for some } x \neq 0 && \text{(F1)} \\ &\iff A - \lambda I \text{ is not invertible} \iff \operatorname{rank}(A-\lambda I) < n && \text{(F3)} \\ &\iff \det(\lambda I - A) = (-1)^n \det(A - \lambda I) = 0 && \text{(F3, F6)} \end{aligned}$$

□

2. The characteristic polynomial

Theorem 3. Let $A = (a_{ij}) \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ and $\operatorname{tr} A = a_{11} + \cdots + a_{nn}$.

(a) There is exactly one polynomial p_A with $p_A(c) = \det(cI - A)$ for all $c \in \mathbb{R}$, the **characteristic polynomial** $p_A(t) = \det(tI - A)$. So $\det(tI - A) = q(t)$ for all $t \in \mathbb{R} \Rightarrow p_A = q$.

(b) p_A is monic of degree n; its coefficient of t^{n-1} is $-\operatorname{tr} A$; its constant term is $(-1)^n \det A$.

(c) $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$ is an eigenvalue of A (Definition 1) $\iff p_A(\lambda) = 0$. So A has at most n such eigenvalues.

Proof. (a)

- Claim: if $M(t) \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times m}$ has entries $\alpha_{ij} + \beta_{ij}t$ ($\alpha_{ij}, \beta_{ij} \in \mathbb{R}$) and $\beta_{ij} \neq 0$ occurs in at most d rows, then $\det M(t) = q(t)$ ($t \in \mathbb{R}$) for a polynomial q, $q = 0$ or $\deg q \leqslant d$.
- Induction on m. $m = 1$: $q = \alpha_{11} + \beta_{11}t$ (F6). No $\beta_{ij} \neq 0$ (e.g. $d = 0$): $q = \det M(0)$. Otherwise expand along a row i with some $\beta_{ij} \neq 0$ (F7); each $M(t)(i|j)$ has $\beta \neq 0$ in at most $d-1$ rows, so $q = \sum_j (-1)^{i+j}(\alpha_{ij} + \beta_{ij}t)q_j$ with $q_j = 0$ or $\deg q_j \leqslant d-1$ (induction, F9).
- The claim for $tI - A$ ($d = n$) gives p_A. Two such polynomials agree on $\mathbb{R}$, so they are equal (F11).

(b) Induction on n; $n = 1$: $p_A = t - a_{11}$ (F6). For $n \geqslant 2$, as $(tI - A)(1|1) = tI_{n-1} - A(1|1)$, expanding along row 1 (F7) gives

$$p_A(t) = (t - a_{11})\, p_{A(1|1)}(t) + \sum_{j=2}^{n} (-1)^{1+j}(-a_{1j}) \det\Big((tI - A)(1|j)\Big)$$

- $j \geqslant 2$: row j of $tI - A$ loses its only t, so $(tI - A)(1|j)$ has t in at most $n-2$ rows; its determinant is 0 or of degree $\leqslant n-2$ (claim).
- Induction: $(t - a_{11})\Big(t^{n-1} - \operatorname{tr} A(1|1)\, t^{n-2} + r\Big) = t^n - \Big(a_{11} + \operatorname{tr} A(1|1)\Big)t^{n-1} + s$, where r, s are 0 or of degree $\leqslant n-3$, $\leqslant n-2$ (F9); $a_{11} + \operatorname{tr} A(1|1) = \operatorname{tr} A$.
- So $p_A = t^n - (\operatorname{tr} A)\, t^{n-1} + (0 \text{ or degree} \leqslant n-2)$, by (a).

Constant term (every n): $p_A(0) = \det(-A) = (-1)^n \det A$ (F6).

(c) Theorem 2 and (a); at most n roots by (b) and F11. □

Example 4. Find the eigenvalues and eigenspaces of

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & 0 & -2 \\ -1 & 2 & 3 \end{pmatrix}$$

Solution.

p_A, expanding along row 1 (F7):

$$\det(tI - A) = \det \begin{pmatrix} t-1 & -2 & -1 \\ -2 & t & 2 \\ 1 & -2 & t-3 \end{pmatrix} = (t-1)\Big(t(t-3)+4\Big) + 2\Big(-2(t-3)-2\Big) - (4-t)$$
$$= (t^3 - 4t^2 + 7t - 4) + (-4t + 8) + (t - 4) = t^3 - 4t^2 + 4t = t(t-2)^2$$

Eigenvalues 0, 2 (Theorem 3(c)).

$\lambda = 0$: reduce $A - 0I = A$; a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A)$:

$$A \xrightarrow[R_3 \leftarrow R_3 + R_1]{R_2 \leftarrow R_2 - 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & -4 & -4 \\ 0 & 4 & 4 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \leftarrow R_3 + R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & -4 & -4 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$
$$\xrightarrow{R_2 \leftarrow -\frac{1}{4}R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftarrow R_1 - 2R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

Free unknown x_3; special solution $(1, -1, 1)'$, a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A)$ (F5).

$\lambda = 2$: reduce $A - 2I$; a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A - 2I)$:

$$A - 2I = \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 2 & 1 \\ 2 & -2 & -2 \\ -1 & 2 & 1 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_3 \leftarrow R_3 - R_1]{R_2 \leftarrow R_2 + 2R_1} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 2 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_2 \leftarrow \frac{1}{2}R_2]{R_1 \leftarrow -R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftarrow R_1 + 2R_2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 0 & -1 \\ 0 & 1 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

Special solution $(1, 0, 1)'$, a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A - 2I)$ (F5).

Definition 5. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$. By Theorem 3(b) and F12, $p_A = (t - \lambda_1) \cdots (t - \lambda_n)$ with $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n \in \mathbb{C}$, unique up to order: the **eigenvalues** of A, listed with multiplicity; they are the roots of p_A. The **algebraic multiplicity** of $c \in \mathbb{C}$ is $a_A(c) = \#\{i : \lambda_i = c\}$; c is **simple** if $a_A(c) = 1$. The real λ_i are the eigenvalues of Definition 1 (Theorem 3(c)). From now on "eigenvalue" has this meaning; eigenvectors and eigenspaces belong to real eigenvalues only.

In Example 4: eigenvalues 0, 2, 2; $a_A(0) = 1$, $a_A(2) = 2$.

Example 6. Find the eigenvalues of

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & -1 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$

Solution. Expanding along column 3 (F7), and as $(t - 2 - \mathrm{i})(t - 2 + \mathrm{i}) = (t-2)^2 - \mathrm{i}^2$,

$$\det(tI - A) = \det \begin{pmatrix} t-2 & 1 & 0 \\ -1 & t-2 & 0 \\ -1 & -1 & t-1 \end{pmatrix} = (t-1)\Big((t-2)^2 + 1\Big) = (t-1)\Big(t - (2+\mathrm{i})\Big)\Big(t - (2-\mathrm{i})\Big)$$

Eigenvalues 1, $2 + \mathrm{i}$, $2 - \mathrm{i}$ (Definition 5); only 1 is real. A real matrix can have eigenvalues that are not real.

3. Similar matrices

Theorem 7. Let $A, P \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$, P invertible, and $B = P^{-1}AP$ (B is **similar** to A). Then $p_B = p_A$. So A, B have the same eigenvalues with the same algebraic multiplicities, $\operatorname{tr} B = \operatorname{tr} A$ and $\det B = \det A$.

Proof.
$\det(cI - B) = \det(cI - A)$ for $c \in \mathbb{R}$:

$$cI - B = P^{-1}(cI)P - P^{-1}AP = P^{-1}(cI - A)P \qquad \text{(F1)}$$
$$\det(cI - B) = \det P^{-1} \det(cI - A) \det P = \det(cI - A) \qquad \text{(F6)}$$
$$\det P^{-1} \det P = \det(P^{-1}P) = \det I = 1 \qquad \text{(F6)}$$

So $p_B = p_A$ (Theorem 3(a)); eigenvalues, tr, det are read off p_A (Definition 5, Theorem 3(b)).

□

Theorem 8. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$.

(a) If $Ax = \lambda x$, $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, $x \neq 0$: $A^k x = \lambda^k x$ ($k = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$), $f(A)x = f(\lambda)x$ for every real polynomial f, and $(A + cI)x = (\lambda + c)x$.

(b) If moreover A is invertible: $\lambda \neq 0$ and $A^{-1}x = \lambda^{-1}x$.

(c) If A has the eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$, then $A + cI$ has the eigenvalues $\lambda_1 + c, \ldots, \lambda_n + c$.

Proof.
(a) by induction on k, then $f(A)x$ and $(A + cI)x$; (b) $\lambda \neq 0$, then $A^{-1}x$:

$$A^0 x = x, \qquad A^{k+1}x = A^k(Ax) = \lambda A^k x = \lambda^{k+1}x \qquad \text{(induction, F1)}$$
$$f(A)x = \textstyle\sum_k b_k A^k x = \sum_k b_k \lambda^k x = f(\lambda)x \qquad (f = \sum_k b_k t^k)$$
$$(A + cI)x = Ax + cx = (\lambda + c)x \qquad \text{(F1)}$$
$$\lambda = 0 \implies Ax = 0,\ x \neq 0 \implies A \text{ not invertible } \text{✘} \qquad \text{((b); F3)}$$
$$x = A^{-1}(Ax) = \lambda A^{-1}x \implies A^{-1}x = \lambda^{-1}x \qquad \text{(F1)}$$

(c) For $s \in \mathbb{R}$, with $p_A = (t - \lambda_1) \cdots (t - \lambda_n)$ (Definition 5):

$$\det\Big(sI - (A + cI)\Big) = \det\Big((s - c)I - A\Big) = p_A(s - c) \qquad \text{(F1, Theorem 3(a))}$$
$$= \Big(s - (\lambda_1 + c)\Big) \cdots \Big(s - (\lambda_n + c)\Big)$$

So $p_{A+cI} = \Big(t - (\lambda_1 + c)\Big) \cdots \Big(t - (\lambda_n + c)\Big)$ (Theorem 3(a)): the eigenvalues of $A + cI$, listed with multiplicity, are $\lambda_1 + c, \ldots, \lambda_n + c$ (Definition 5, F12).

□

Theorem 9. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ have the eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$. Then $\operatorname{tr} A = \lambda_1 + \cdots + \lambda_n$ and $\det A = \lambda_1 \cdots \lambda_n$. So A is invertible $\iff$ 0 is not an eigenvalue of A.

Proof.
Coefficients of $p_A = (t - \lambda_1) \cdots (t - \lambda_n)$ (Definition 5):

$$t^{n-1}: \quad -\operatorname{tr} A = -(\lambda_1 + \cdots + \lambda_n) \qquad \text{(Theorem 3(b), F12)}$$
$$t^0: \quad (-1)^n \det A = (-1)^n \lambda_1 \cdots \lambda_n \qquad \text{(Theorem 3(b), F12)}$$
$$A \text{ invertible} \iff \det A \neq 0 \iff \lambda_i \neq 0 \text{ for all } i \qquad \text{(F3; } zw = 0 \Rightarrow z = 0 \text{ or } w = 0\text{)}$$

□

Example 4: $\operatorname{tr} A = 1 + 0 + 3 = 0 + 2 + 2$, $\det A = 0 \cdot 2 \cdot 2 = 0$, so A is not invertible. Example 6: $\operatorname{tr} A = 2 + 2 + 1 = 1 + (2 + \mathrm{i}) + (2 - \mathrm{i})$, $\det A = 1 \cdot (2 + \mathrm{i})(2 - \mathrm{i}) = 5$.

4. Independence and multiplicities

Theorem 10. Let $v_1, \dots, v_m$ be eigenvectors of $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ for real eigenvalues $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_m$, with $\lambda_i \neq \lambda_j$ for $i \neq j$. Then $v_1, \dots, v_m$ are linearly independent. If A has n distinct real eigenvalues, eigenvectors for them form a basis of $\mathbb{R}^n$.

Proof. Induction on m; $m = 1$: $c_1 v_1 = 0$, $v_1 \neq 0 \Rightarrow c_1 = 0$ (F4). Let $m \geqslant 2$ and $c_1 v_1 + \cdots + c_m v_m = 0$.

- A times it minus λ_m times it ($Av_i = \lambda_i v_i$, F1): $c_1(\lambda_1 - \lambda_m)v_1 + \cdots + c_{m-1}(\lambda_{m-1} - \lambda_m)v_{m-1} = 0$.
- Induction hypothesis: $c_i(\lambda_i - \lambda_m) = 0$, so $c_i = 0$ for $i < m$ ($\lambda_i \neq \lambda_m$).
- Then $c_m v_m = 0$ and $v_m \neq 0$, so $c_m = 0$ (F4).

Last sentence: n independent vectors in $\mathbb{R}^n$ form a basis (F4). □

Definition 11. For $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ and $c \in \mathbb{R}$, the **geometric multiplicity** of c is $g_A(c) = \dim \mathcal{N}(A - cI) = n - \operatorname{rank}(A - cI)$ (F5). So $g_A(c) \geqslant 1 \iff c$ is an eigenvalue (Theorem 2).

Theorem 12. If $c \in \mathbb{R}$ is an eigenvalue of $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$, then $1 \leqslant g_A(c) \leqslant a_A(c)$. If c is simple, $g_A(c) = 1$.

Proof.
- $g = g_A(c) \geqslant 1$ (Definition 11). Extend a basis $x_1, \dots, x_g$ of $\mathcal{N}(A - cI)$ to a basis $x_1, \dots, x_n$ of $\mathbb{R}^n$ (F4); $P = [x_1 \ \cdots \ x_n]$ is invertible (F3).
- $Ax_j = cx_j = P(ce_j)$ for $j \leqslant g$; $Ax_j = Pm_j$ for some $m_j \in \mathbb{R}^n$ for $j > g$, as $x_1, \dots, x_n$ span $\mathbb{R}^n$ (F2). So $AP = PM$ for $M = [ce_1 \ \cdots \ ce_g \ m_{g+1} \ \cdots \ m_n]$ (F2), and $M = P^{-1}AP$. If $g = n$: $M = cI$, $p_A = p_M = (t - c)^n$ (Theorems 7, 3(a); F6), and $a_A(c) = n$.
- If $g < n$, $M = \left(\begin{smallmatrix} cI_g & K \\ 0 & D \end{smallmatrix}\right)$ with $D \in \mathbb{R}^{(n-g)\times(n-g)}$, and for $s \in \mathbb{R}$

$$sI - M = \begin{pmatrix} (s-c)I_g & -K \\ 0 & sI_{n-g} - D \end{pmatrix} \qquad \text{(F1)}$$

$$\det(sI - M) = \det\Big((s-c)I_g\Big)\det(sI_{n-g} - D) = (s-c)^g p_D(s) \qquad \text{(F8, F6)}$$

  So $p_A = p_M = (t - c)^g p_D$ (Theorems 7 and 3(a)).
- With $p_D = (t - \delta_1)\cdots(t - \delta_{n-g})$ (Theorem 3(b), F12), the eigenvalues of A are c (g times) and $\delta_1, \dots, \delta_{n-g}$ (Definition 5, F12); so $a_A(c) \geqslant g$.
- c simple: $1 \leqslant g_A(c) \leqslant a_A(c) = 1$. □

In Example 4: $g_A(2) = 1 < 2 = a_A(2)$.

5. Diagonalization

Definition 13. $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ is **diagonalizable** if $P^{-1}AP = \Lambda$ for an invertible $P \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ and a diagonal $\Lambda = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n)$ (diagonal entries $\lambda_i \in \mathbb{R}$).

Theorem 14. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times n}$ have the distinct real eigenvalues $c_1, \dots, c_k$, and $W_i = \mathcal{N}(A - c_i I)$.

(a) For an invertible $P = [u_1 \ \cdots \ u_n]$ and $\Lambda = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n)$: $P^{-1}AP = \Lambda \iff Au_j = \lambda_j u_j$ ($j = 1, \dots, n$). If so, $\lambda_1, \dots, \lambda_n$ are the eigenvalues of A.

(b) The following are equivalent: (i) A is diagonalizable; (ii) $\mathbb{R}^n$ has a basis of eigenvectors of A; (iii) all eigenvalues of A are real and $g_A(c_i) = a_A(c_i)$ for each i; (iv) $g_A(c_1) + \cdots + g_A(c_k) = n$. In (iv), bases of $W_1, \dots, W_k$ together form a basis of $\mathbb{R}^n$.

(c) If A has n distinct real eigenvalues, then A is diagonalizable.

Proof. (a)

$$P^{-1}AP = \Lambda \iff AP = P\Lambda \qquad \text{(F1)}$$
$$\iff Au_j = \mathrm{col}_j(AP) = \mathrm{col}_j(P\Lambda) = \lambda_j u_j \text{ for all } j \qquad \text{(F2)}$$
$$P^{-1}AP = \Lambda \implies p_A = p_\Lambda = (t-\lambda_1)\cdots(t-\lambda_n) \qquad \text{(Theorems 7, 3(a); F6)}$$

So $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n$ are the eigenvalues of A (Definition 5).

(b)

- (i)⇔(ii): by (a), as the columns of an invertible P form a basis of $\mathbb{R}^n$ and are nonzero, and a basis $u_1, \ldots, u_n$ gives an invertible P (F3, F4).
- (i)⇒(iii): by (a), the eigenvalues are the real λ_j, and $a_A(c_i) = d_i = \#\{j : \lambda_j = c_i\}$. The jth entry of $(\Lambda - c_iI)x$ is $(\lambda_j - c_i)x_j$, so $\mathcal{N}(\Lambda - c_iI)$ has the basis $\{e_j : \lambda_j = c_i\}$, and
$$g_A(c_i) = n - \mathrm{rank}(A - c_iI) = n - \mathrm{rank}\Big(P^{-1}(A - c_iI)P\Big) = n - \mathrm{rank}(\Lambda - c_iI) = d_i \qquad \text{(F5)}$$
- (iii)⇒(iv): each eigenvalue is one of $c_1, \ldots, c_k$, so $\sum_i g_A(c_i) = \sum_i a_A(c_i) = n$.
- (iv)⇒(ii): let $w_l \in W_l$, $w_1 + \cdots + w_k = 0$. For the real polynomial $f_i = \prod_{j\neq i} \frac{t-c_j}{c_i-c_j}$ ($f_1 = 1$ if $k = 1$), $f_i(c_l) = 1$ if $l = i$ and 0 if $l \neq i$; $f(A)w_l = f(c_l)w_l$ (Theorem 8(a); trivial if $w_l = 0$). So $0 = f_i(A)(w_1 + \cdots + w_k) = f_i(c_1)w_1 + \cdots + f_i(c_k)w_k = w_i$.
- So bases $v_{l1}, \ldots, v_{lg_l}$ of the W_l ($g_l = g_A(c_l)$) are together independent: $\sum_{l,r} \gamma_{lr}v_{lr} = 0$ is $w_1 + \cdots + w_k = 0$ with $w_l = \sum_r \gamma_{lr}v_{lr} \in W_l$; so all $w_l = 0$, all $\gamma_{lr} = 0$. These n eigenvectors form a basis of $\mathbb{R}^n$ (F4).

(c) n eigenvectors for the n eigenvalues form a basis (Theorem 10): (ii) holds. □

Not diagonalizable: Example 4 ($g_A(2) = 1 < 2 = a_A(2)$) and Example 6 ($2 \pm \mathrm{i}$ are not real).

Example 15. Diagonalize A: find an invertible P and a diagonal Λ with $P^{-1}AP = \Lambda$, where

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 5 & -6 & -6 \\ -1 & 4 & 2 \\ 3 & -6 & -4 \end{pmatrix}$$

Solution.

p_A: $\mathrm{col}_2 \leftarrow \mathrm{col}_2 - \mathrm{col}_3$, then take $t-2$ out of column 2 (F6):

$$\det(tI-A) = \det\begin{pmatrix} t-5 & 6 & 6 \\ 1 & t-4 & -2 \\ -3 & 6 & t+4 \end{pmatrix} = \det\begin{pmatrix} t-5 & 0 & 6 \\ 1 & t-2 & -2 \\ -3 & 2-t & t+4 \end{pmatrix} = (t-2)\det\begin{pmatrix} t-5 & 0 & 6 \\ 1 & 1 & -2 \\ -3 & -1 & t+4 \end{pmatrix}$$

$R_3 \leftarrow R_3 + R_2$ (F6), expand along column 2 (F7):

$$\det(tI - A) = (t-2)\det\begin{pmatrix} t-5 & 0 & 6 \\ 1 & 1 & -2 \\ -2 & 0 & t+2 \end{pmatrix} = (t-2)\det\begin{pmatrix} t-5 & 6 \\ -2 & t+2 \end{pmatrix}$$
$$= (t-2)(t^2 - 3t + 2) = (t-1)(t-2)^2$$

Eigenvalues $1, 2, 2$; $a_A(1) = 1$, $a_A(2) = 2$.

$\lambda = 1$: echelon form of $A - I$, then back substitution:

$$A - I = \begin{pmatrix} 4 & -6 & -6 \\ -1 & 3 & 2 \\ 3 & -6 & -5 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 3 & 2 \\ 4 & -6 & -6 \\ 3 & -6 & -5 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_3 \leftarrow R_3 + 3R_1]{R_2 \leftarrow R_2 + 4R_1} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 6 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \end{pmatrix}$$
$$\xrightarrow{R_2 \leftrightarrow R_3} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 6 & 2 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_3 \leftarrow R_3 - 2R_2} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 3 & 2 \\ 0 & 3 & 1 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

$\operatorname{rank}(A - I) = 2$, $g_A(1) = 1$ (F5). $-x_1 + 3x_2 + 2x_3 = 0$, $3x_2 + x_3 = 0$; $x_3 = 3$: $\alpha_1 = (3, -1, 3)'$, a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A - I)$ (F5, F4).

$\lambda = 2$: reduce $A - 2I$; special solutions:

$$A - 2I = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & -6 & -6 \\ -1 & 2 & 2 \\ 3 & -6 & -6 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftrightarrow R_2} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 2 & 2 \\ 3 & -6 & -6 \\ 3 & -6 & -6 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow[R_3 \leftarrow R_3 + 3R_1]{R_2 \leftarrow R_2 + 3R_1} \begin{pmatrix} -1 & 2 & 2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix} \xrightarrow{R_1 \leftarrow -R_1} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & -2 & -2 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \\ 0 & 0 & 0 \end{pmatrix}$$

$g_A(2) = 3 - 1 = 2$; special solutions $\alpha_2 = (2, 1, 0)'$, $\alpha_3 = (2, 0, 1)'$, a basis of $\mathcal{N}(A - 2I)$ (F5).

P and Λ:

$g_A(1) + g_A(2) = 3$: $\alpha_1, \alpha_2, \alpha_3$ form a basis of $\mathbb{R}^3$ (Theorem 14(b)), so $P = [\alpha_1\ \alpha_2\ \alpha_3]$ is invertible (F3), and $AP = P\Lambda$ gives $P^{-1}AP = \Lambda$ (Theorem 14(a)):

$$P = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 2 & 2 \\ -1 & 1 & 0 \\ 3 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad \Lambda = \operatorname{diag}(1, 2, 2), \qquad AP = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 4 & 4 \\ -1 & 2 & 0 \\ 3 & 0 & 2 \end{pmatrix} = P\Lambda$$

Theorem 16. If $A = P\Lambda P^{-1}$ with $P \in \mathbb{R}^{n \times n}$ invertible and $\Lambda = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_n)$, then $A^k = P\Lambda^k P^{-1} = P \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1^k, \ldots, \lambda_n^k) P^{-1}$ for $k = 0, 1, 2, \ldots$

Proof.

Induction on k; then Λ^k:

$$A^0 = I = P\Lambda^0 P^{-1}$$
$$A^{k+1} = A^k A = P\Lambda^k P^{-1} P\Lambda P^{-1} = P\Lambda^{k+1} P^{-1} \qquad \text{(F1)}$$

Diagonal matrices (column j of the product is $a_j b_j e_j$; F2):

$$\operatorname{diag}(a_1, \ldots, a_n) \operatorname{diag}(b_1, \ldots, b_n) = \operatorname{diag}(a_1 b_1, \ldots, a_n b_n)$$

So $\Lambda^k = \operatorname{diag}(\lambda_1^k, \ldots, \lambda_n^k)$.

□

6. The products AB and BA

Theorem 17. Let $A \in \mathbb{R}^{m\times n}$ and $B \in \mathbb{R}^{n\times m}$.

(a) $t^n p_{AB} = t^m p_{BA}$. If $m \leqslant n$ (if $m \geqslant n$, exchange A and B): $p_{BA} = t^{n-m} p_{AB}$; the eigenvalues of BA are those of AB and $n-m$ zeros. So AB, BA have the same nonzero eigenvalues, with the same algebraic multiplicities.

(b) If $ABx = \lambda x$, $\lambda \in \mathbb{R}$, $\lambda \neq 0$, $x \in \mathbb{R}^m$, $x \neq 0$, then $BA(Bx) = \lambda Bx$ and $Bx \neq 0$.

Proof. (a) For $t \in \mathbb{R}$:

$$M = \begin{pmatrix} tI_m & A \\ B & I_n \end{pmatrix}$$

$$\det M = \det I_n \det(tI_m - AI_n^{-1}B) = p_{AB}(t) \qquad \text{(F8)}$$

$$\det M = \det(tI_m) \det\Big(I_n - B(tI_m)^{-1}A\Big) = t^m \det\Big(t^{-1}(tI_n - BA)\Big) \qquad \text{(F8, } t \neq 0\text{)}$$

$$= t^{m-n} p_{BA}(t) \qquad \text{(F6)}$$

So $t^n p_{AB}(t) = t^m p_{BA}(t)$ for all $t \neq 0$, and $t^n p_{AB} = t^m p_{BA}$ (F11). If $m \leqslant n$, $t^m(t^{n-m} p_{AB}) = t^m p_{BA}$ gives $p_{BA} = t^{n-m} p_{AB}$ (F9); with $p_{AB} = (t-\mu_1)\cdots(t-\mu_m)$ (Definition 5), the eigenvalues of BA are $\mu_1, \ldots, \mu_m$ and $n-m$ zeros (F12). So $a_{BA}(c) = a_{AB}(c)$ for $c \neq 0$ (Definition 5). If $m \geqslant n$, the same with A, B exchanged gives $p_{AB} = t^{m-n} p_{BA}$.

(b) $BA(Bx) = B(ABx) = \lambda Bx$ (F1). If $Bx = 0$: $\lambda x = ABx = 0$, $\lambda \neq 0$, so $x = 0$ (F4) ✘ □

Example 18. Find the eigenvalues of $A'A$ and AA', and an eigenvector of AA' for each eigenvalue, where

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 0 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 1 \\ -1 & 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad A'A = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 \\ 0 & 1 & 3 \end{pmatrix}, \qquad AA' = \begin{pmatrix} 2 & 1 & 1 & -1 \\ 1 & 2 & 1 & 0 \\ 1 & 1 & 2 & 1 \\ -1 & 0 & 1 & 2 \end{pmatrix}$$

Solution.

$p_{A'A}$, expanding along row 1 (F7), and $p_{AA'}$:

$$\det(tI_3 - A'A) = \det \begin{pmatrix} t-3 & -1 & 0 \\ -1 & t-2 & -1 \\ 0 & -1 & t-3 \end{pmatrix} = (t-3)\Big((t-2)(t-3)-1\Big) - (t-3)$$

$$= (t-3)(t^2 - 5t + 4) = (t-1)(t-3)(t-4)$$

Theorem 17(a), with A', A in place of A, B ($m = 3$, $n = 4$): $p_{AA'} = t\, p_{A'A} = t(t-1)(t-3)(t-4)$. Eigenvalues: $1, 3, 4$ for $A'A$; $0, 1, 3, 4$ for AA'.

$\lambda = 4, 3, 1$: eigenvectors of $A'A$, mapped by A (Theorem 17(b) with A', A in place of A, B):

$$A'A(1,1,1)' = (4,4,4)' = 4(1,1,1)', \qquad A(1,1,1)' = (2,2,2,0)'$$

$$A'A(-1,0,1)' = (-3,0,3)' = 3(-1,0,1)', \qquad A(-1,0,1)' = (-1,0,1,2)'$$

$$A'A(1,-2,1)' = (1,-2,1)' = 1(1,-2,1)', \qquad A(1,-2,1)' = (-1,2,-1,0)'$$

$(2,2,2,0)'$, $(-1,0,1,2)'$, $(-1,2,-1,0)'$ are eigenvectors of AA' for 4, 3, 1.

$\lambda = 0$: $\mathcal{N}(AA')$, by Theorem 12:

0 is a simple eigenvalue of AA', so $g_{AA'}(0) = 1$ (Theorem 12). As $A'(1,0,-1,1)' = (1+0+0-1,\ 1+0-1+0,\ 0+0-1+1)' = 0$, $AA'(1,0,-1,1)' = 0$: $(1,0,-1,1)'$ is a basis of $\mathcal{N}(AA')$ (F4).

Practice. The Exercises and Problems of Chapter 7 of the textbook.